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From the editor-in-chief

There's a somewhat sinister line from one of the Godfather movies which went like this: 'Real power can't be given. It must be taken'. I would like to refine that a little: real power is not inherited, it is carefully acquired and judiciously exercised. It is intangible. It is indefinable but it is unmistakably and instantly recognised when used. It cannot be gained by wealth or position alone; there are many people with both wealth and position who are not really powerful. Outside the boundaries of governmental authority, real power is in effect the ability to influence change at the highest levels—in your own field and in any wider arena. It is the ability to impact more people than only those under your direct control. It is also reflected in subtle ways. Those whose calls you must return. Those whose invitations you can't refuse. Those who you go out of the way to greet. Those whose presence enhances your status. Above all, power is transient, as several people will discover in the seventh annual INDIA TODAY High & Mighty list of the 50 most powerful people in the country.

Reflecting the economic meltdown this year, it has the largest number of businessmen dropped from the list since it started in 2003. Till this year, the number of businessmen on the list was rising every year and had reached 25. This year it dropped to 21. Of the 14 people whose ranks have slipped, seven are businessmen.

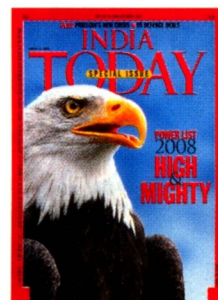
INDIA TODAY's list of the 50 most powerful people in the country also reflects how fluid India's power structure is. Only 18 people have appeared in all our seven lists. Even though this is election year, politicians without official positions but real clout are reducing in number—there are only three in our 2009 Power List. Interestingly, the number of public intellectuals—who would like to believe they keep the rest of us honest—seem to have made a comeback in these recessionary times, accounting for nine of the top 50. Sadly, the number of women in the top 50 has fallen to its lowest levels in seven years, with only two women making the cut.

We constantly try to update and expand this list; in 2006 we introduced an 'official' Power List that comprises the 10 most powerful politicians and government officials. The official list reflects the changing political equations in the country. It is hardly surprising that the most prominent name missing from the official list this year is Prakash Karat, who until the signing of the Indo-US nuclear deal, was holding the Government hostage.

This year we add another feature to the Power List, identifying the 20 most powerful global Indians, call it the diaspora Power List if you like. I must say it is a very impressive list containing internationally recognised names from business, media and the arts.

As the time for our Power List issue nears, we get casual queries about the new rankings, who's in, who's out and whether it contains any 'surprises'. Always, there is much curiosity before and some heartburn after the rankings are released. For those who see themselves as contenders for the power list, there can be no credible powerful people list without their name on it. C'est la vie!

(Aroon Purie)



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